

unprepossessing. “He exhibited that preoccupied stare of the thoughtful scholar that so commonly impresses the undiscerning as imbecile,” writes a biographer.

Strangely, Hume during his day was not mainly known for the works that generated his current reputation—he became rich and famous through writing a bestselling history of England. Ironically, when Hume was alive, his philosophical works, to which we now attach his fame, “fell deadborn off the presses,” while the works for which he was famous at the time are now harder to find. Hume wrote with such clarity that he puts to shame almost all current thinkers, and certainly the entire German graduate curriculum. Unlike Kant, Fichte, Schopenhauer, and Hegel, Hume is the kind of thinker who is *sometimes* read by the person mentioning his work.

I often hear “Hume’s problem” mentioned in connection with the problem of induction, but the problem is old, older than the interesting Scotsman, perhaps as old as philosophy itself, maybe as old as olive-grove conversations. Let us go back into the past, as it was formulated with no less precision by the ancients.

Sextus the (Alas) Empirical

The violently antiacademic writer, and antidogma activist, Sextus Empiricus operated close to a millennium and a half before Hume, and formulated the turkey problem with great precision. We know very little about him; we do not know whether he was a philosopher or more of a copyist of philosophical texts by authors obscure to us today. We surmise that he lived in Alexandria in the second century of our era. He belonged to a school of medicine called “empirical,” since its practitioners doubted theories and causality and relied on past experience as guidance in their treatment, though not putting much trust in it. Furthermore, they did not trust that anatomy revealed function too obviously. The most famous proponent of the empirical school, Menodotus of Nicomedia, who merged empiricism and philosophical skepticism, was said to keep medicine an art, not a “science,” and insulate its practice from the problems of dogmatic science. The practice of medicine explains the addition of *empiricus* (“the empirical”) to Sextus’s name.

Sextus represented and jotted down the ideas of the school of the Pyrrhonian skeptics who were after some form of intellectual therapy resulting from the suspension of belief. Do you face the possibility of an adverse event? Don’t worry. Who knows, it may turn out to be good for you. Doubting the consequences of an outcome will allow you to remain imperturbable. The Pyrrhonian skeptics were docile citizens who followed customs and traditions whenever possible, but taught themselves to